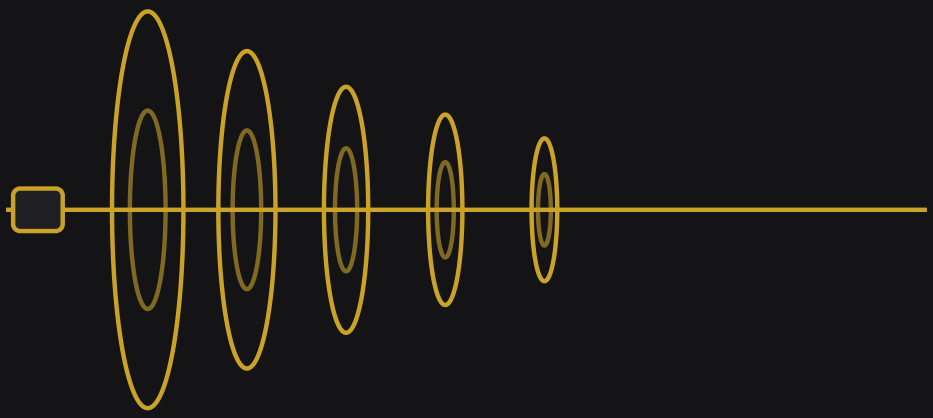


The 3-Session Week

The least training that makes a man of 35 to 50 measurably stronger. Six lifts, three sessions, the first four weeks written out.

By Daniel Reyes, strength coach, former physiotherapist · forgefitness.example.com

Page 1 · Read this first

Volume isn't the lever. Progression is.

Most programs are built around how much: six days, two hours, a split for every muscle. That works for a man with nothing else on and a body that recovers overnight. For you it fails in week three, and the failure feels like a character flaw. It isn't. It's arithmetic.

Strength comes from three things, in order: a small set of lifts done well; a rule that adds weight only when the last set was clean; enough recovery that the next session is better than the last. Three sessions a week give you all three.

This guide gives you the template (page 4), the six lifts with cues (page 5), the first four weeks programmed with starting weights (page 6), the rule (page 7), the warm-up (page 8), the "train around" table (page 9), the hotel-gym version (page 10), and what to do in week five (page 11).

One rule for the month

When in doubt, lighter. The bar will catch up.

Who this is for: men 35 to 50 who are healthy enough to lift. If a doctor has told you not to, follow the doctor. If you have a current injury, see page 9 before session one.

Page 2 · How to use this guide

1. Print pages 4 and 6. Put them in the bag.
2. Pick your equipment track: full gym, home rack and barbell, or dumbbells. Page 10 is the hotel version.
3. Session one: the warm-up (page 8), then squat, bench, row at the page-6 starting weights. Forty-five minutes.
4. Log every session: weight, reps, and one word (clean / grind / missed). Page 12.
5. Apply the rule on page 7 every session after the first. That's the program.

Page 3 · The three levers

Progression. Add 2.5 kg to a lift when the last set was clean. Repeat the weight when it wasn't. Over four weeks that's up to 30 kg on a squat without a single hard decision.

Recovery. Forty-eight hours between heavy sessions. At 45 you recover slower than at 25, and the program respects that instead of pretending.

Consistency. Three sessions that fit a real week will beat six that don't. The men who get strong are the ones whose plan survives a Tuesday.

Day one, day two, day one again.

Day	Session	Lifts
Mon · day 1	A	**Squat · Bench · Row**
Wed · day 2	B	**Deadlift · Press · Pull-up**
Fri · day 3	A	**Squat · Bench · Row**

Next week: B · A · B. Alternate.

Each session

8-minute warm-up · lift 1: 3 sets of 5 · lift 2: 3 sets of 5 · lift 3: 3 sets of 8 · done. Rest 2 to 3 minutes between heavy sets. Forty-five minutes.

Two days: do A and B with four days between, slightly longer sessions. Four days: the fourth day is a 25-minute walk or the mobility routine, never a fourth lift day.

Page 5 · The six lifts, with cues for men who sit all day

Lift	Set-up	Cue
Squat	Bar on the upper back, feet shoulder-width, toes slightly out. Sit between your knees, not back onto a chair.	*"Knees out, chest up, push the floor away."*
Bench	Shoulder blades together and down, feet flat. Bar to the lower chest, elbows at 45 degrees.	*"Bend the bar."*
Row	Hinge at the hips, flat back, bar to the lower ribs. No heaving.	*"Elbows to the back pockets."*
Deadlift	Bar over mid-foot, shins to the bar, hips higher than knees. Bar stays on the legs.	*"Stand up tall, don't lean back."*
Press	Bar on the front of the shoulders, elbows slightly forward. Head through at the top.	*"Finish with the bar over the mid-foot."*
Pull-up	Full hang, elbows to the ribs. Can't do one yet: band or lat pull-down, 3×8, log the number.	*"Chest to the bar."*

Desk-shoulder note: if the bench or press pinches the front of the shoulder, narrow the grip by a hand's width and see page 9.

Starting weights

Squat 40 kg · bench 30 kg · row 30 kg · deadlift 50 kg · press 20 kg · pull-up: bodyweight, band, or pull-down at a weight you can do for 8. Too heavy for a clean 3×5: go lighter. Feels insulting: do it anyway in week one. The rule catches you up.

Week	Session A (Mon/Fri)	Session B (Wed)	What to expect
1	Squat 3×5 · Bench 3×5 · Row 3×8	Deadlift 3×5 · Press 3×5 · Pull-up 3×8	Everything feels light. Good. Pattern first.
2	+2.5 kg on every clean lift	+2.5 kg on every clean lift	Squat and deadlift move fastest. Some soreness; it fades.
3	+2.5 kg (deadlift +5 kg) where clean	Same	The week other programs collapse. Yours is 45 minutes, three times. Keep it.
4	+2.5 kg where clean	Same	Most men are 15 to 30 kg heavier on the squat than week one. Log it.

Dumbbell track: same sets and reps with goblet squat, dumbbell bench, one-arm row, Romanian deadlift, dumbbell press, band or pull-down. Progress by moving to the next dumbbell when 3×5 is clean.

Page 7 · The rule

After every set, write one word.

Clean: all reps, good form, could have done one more. **Grind**: all reps, ugly last one. **Missed**: short of the reps.

- Last set clean → add 2.5 kg next session (5 kg on deadlift).
- Last set grind → same weight next session.
- Last set missed → same weight; missed twice, drop 10% and build back.

That's every decision in the program. No "how do I feel today." The log decides.

Page 8 · The eight-minute warm-up

1. Two minutes: walk, bike or row, easy.
2. Hips: 10 slow bodyweight squats to your best depth, hold the bottom 2 seconds.
3. Shoulders: 10 band pull-aparts, 10 wall slides.
4. Back: 10 hip hinges with a dowel or broom on the back.
5. The first lift with the empty bar, 2 sets of 5. One set at half your working weight. Then work.

Skip it once and you'll know why it's there.

Page 9 · The “train around” table

It hurts when	Swap	Keep doing
Lower back, squat	Goblet squat or box squat to a high box	Deadlift lighter, Romanian deadlift
Lower back, deadlift	Trap-bar or Romanian deadlift, or rack pull	Squat as normal
Front of shoulder, bench	Dumbbell bench, neutral grip, or floor press	Row, pull-up
Shoulder, press	Landmine or dumbbell press, neutral grip	Bench with narrow grip
Knee, squat	Box squat, slow descent, or leg press	Deadlift, hinge pattern
Elbow, pull-up	Neutral-grip pull-down or ring row	Every thing else

Rule: pain that’s sharp, in a joint, or worse the next day is a swap, not a push-through. Soreness in muscle is normal. If something has hurt for more than two weeks, see a physio.

Page 10 · The hotel-gym version

Hotel gyms have dumbbells to 25 kg, a cable machine, maybe a Smith machine. Same template, same sets and reps.

Session A: goblet squat (or Smith squat) · dumbbell bench · one-arm row. **Session B:** dumbbell Romanian deadlift · dumbbell press · lat pull-down.

Progress by moving up a dumbbell when 3×5 is clean. Log it the same way. A hotel week counts.

If you ran four weeks, compare page 12 to session one. Most men see the squat up 15 to 30 kg and the deadlift more. Keep running the rule for another four weeks exactly as written.

Where this guide stops: the filmed lifts, the week-seven deload (the one that stops week eight from breaking you), the hotel-gym track in full, the Plate Rule for eating, weekly check-ins with Daniel, and the “train around” cues on video.

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Session	Lift 1 (kg · reps · word)	Lift 2	Lift 3	Notes
1 A				
2 B				
3 A				
4 B				
5 A				
6 B				
7 A				
8 B				
9 A				
10 B				
11 A				
12 B				

General strength-training information for healthy adults. Not medical advice. If you have a condition, an injury, or a doctor's instruction about exercise, follow the doctor. Stop any lift that causes sharp joint pain. © Forge Fitness Online Ltd. Print it for yourself; send others to forgefitness.example.com/forge/ebook, it's free there too.